

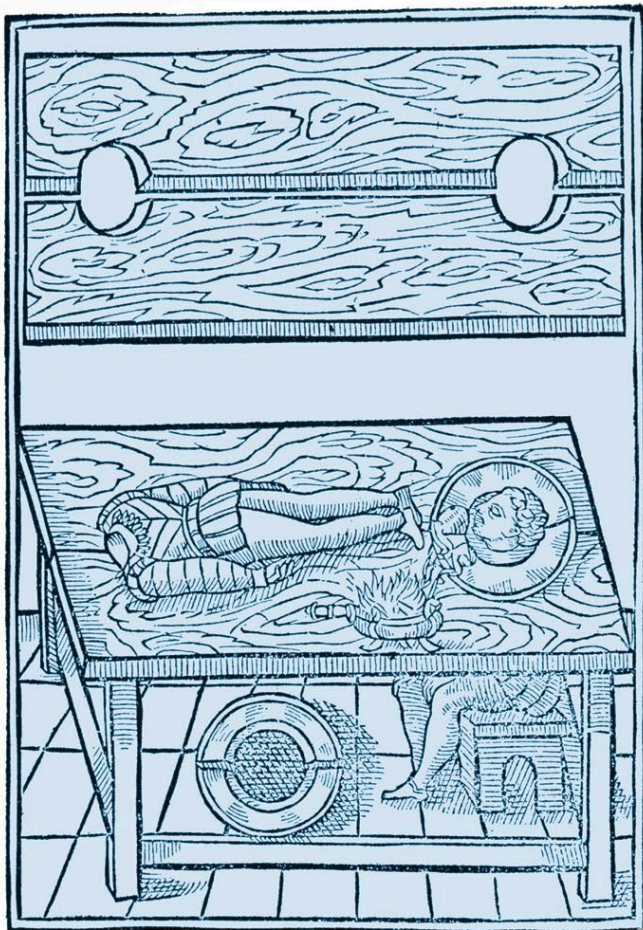
DELUSIONS AND TRICKERY

debunking witchcraft

As the Renaissance spread across Europe in the 16th century, the number of skeptics who doubted the existence of witchcraft or criticized the holding of witch trials and the way they were conducted grew. Such voices strengthened, and by the time of the Enlightenment witchcraft was looked on as a type of fraud rather than magic.

▼ Decapitation trick

In *The Discoverie of Witchcraft*, Reginald Scot explained the “Decollation of John the Baptist,” a trick in which a man was apparently beheaded. In fact, there were two people, one of whose heads was positioned so as to appear severed.

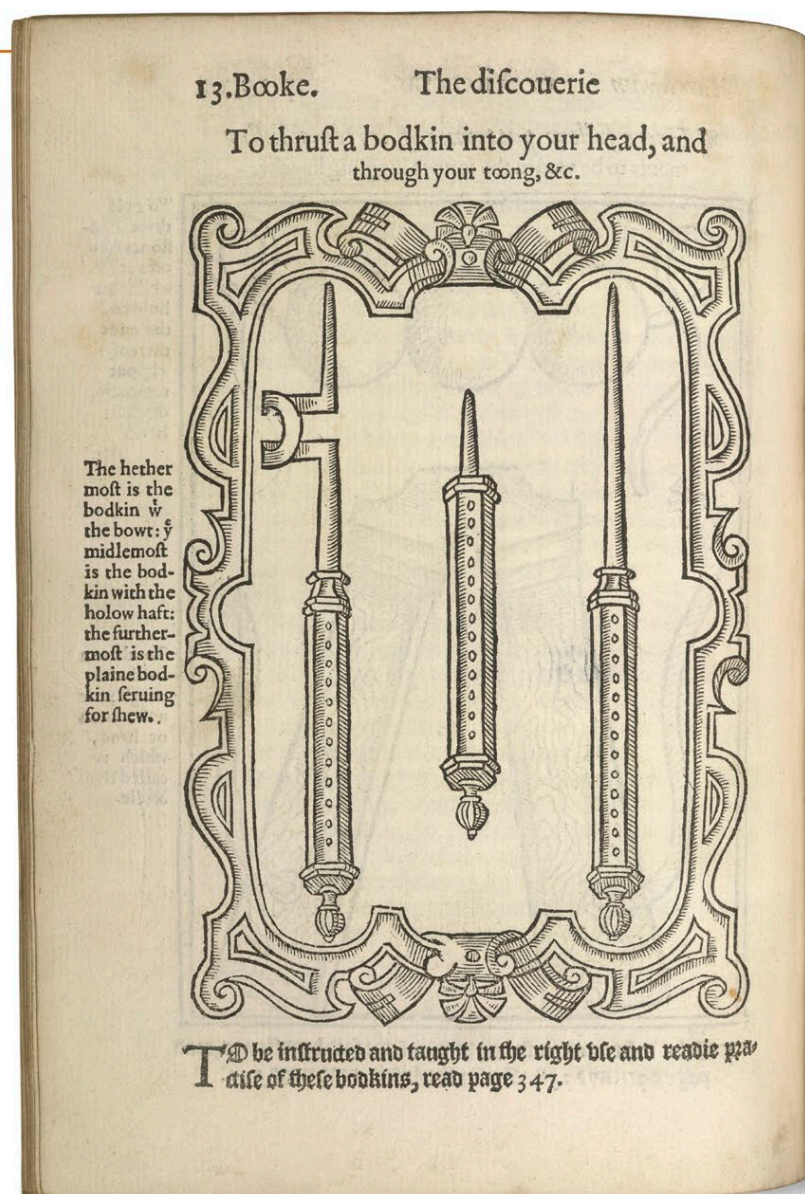


Growing skepticism

There was a tradition of skepticism in the Church and among medieval authors about the existence of witchcraft. In the 16th century, new grounds for disbelief arose, reinforced by the interest of Renaissance scholars in nature and scientific inquiry. In 1520, Italian scholar Pietro Pomponazzi published *On the Causes of Natural Effects*, in which he

argued that phenomena traditionally attributed to witchcraft had perfectly explicable scientific causes.

Such skepticism spread, and critics targeted their attacks on the very foundations of the craze for persecuting supposed witches. In 1566, Johann Weyer, a German court physician, published his *De Praestigiis Daemonum* (“On the Tricks of Demons”),



in which he made the case that the women accused of witchcraft were senile, victims of jealousy, or, as evidenced by their confessions, suffering from melancholy. Weyer's doubts, however, had their limits: he continued to believe that magic was possible and that male sorcerers could invoke demons. Reginald Scot, an English member of parliament, took the attack on belief in witchcraft a stage further in his *The Discoverie of Witchcraft*

“Every old woman with a wrinkled face ... a hairy lip, a gobbertooth, a squint eye ... is not only suspected, but pronounced for a witch.”

JOHN GAULE, *SELECT CASES OF CONSCIENCE TOUCHING WITCHES*, 1646